

# OHIO OWNER-BUILDER PERMIT KIT

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Find who is certified · File what applies anyway · Build to the code

Project Address: \_\_\_\_\_

City / Village / Township: \_\_\_\_\_

County: \_\_\_\_\_

Building Department: \_\_\_\_\_

Local Health District: \_\_\_\_\_

Owner-Builder: \_\_\_\_\_

No certified residential building department here? Write NONE — and read OH.1 first.

Every Ohio statute, code section and requirement in this kit  
is cited on the page it appears on — verified September 2026.

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First Edition — 2026

# How to Use This Kit

Five working documents, from "is anybody certified to inspect this parcel?" to the last inspection.

Ohio does something almost no other state does. It writes **one residential code for the entire state** — the Residential Code of Ohio, which by its own terms governs "every one-, two-, or three-family dwelling" — and then, **inside that same code**, it tells you when you do not have to file anything at all.

## OAC 4101:8-1-01, RCO section 101.5 — the sentence this kit is built around

**"Jurisdiction without a certified residential building department.** If no municipal, township, or county building department is certified by the Board of Building Standards for residential buildings in accordance with section 3781.10(E) of the Revised Code has jurisdiction, **the owner is not required to make submission of construction documents, seek approvals, request inspections, or obtain certificates of occupancy required in this Chapter.**"

Read that twice. It is not a loophole somebody found — it is the code's own text, and the awkward grammar is the state's, not ours. Ohio does not require a city, a township or a county to run a residential building department. Where none is certified, there is no plan review, no permit, no inspection and no certificate of occupancy, because the code itself says so.

**What that does not mean is that the code stops applying.** The standard still governs your house; only the paperwork disappears. And several things that are *not* in the building code apply to your parcel no matter what your county decided — the sewage treatment system permit, the private water system permit, and the contract and lien rules that decide whether you can be made to pay for the same work twice.

## WHAT IS IN THE KIT

### The five documents

|             | Document                            | What it does for you                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|-------------|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>OH.1</b> | Owner-Builder Exemption Walkthrough | Why Ohio has no owner-builder exemption and does not need one, the definition chain that puts your house outside the state trade licenses altogether, and the question that reshapes the whole build: is anybody certified here? <b>Read this first.</b> |
| <b>OH.2</b> | Permit Application Checklist        | What to gather before you file — the approvals that apply wherever you build, the code editions actually in force, and the referenced standard Ohio changed in 2024 that almost every guide still prints wrong.                                          |
| <b>OH.3</b> | Inspection Sequence                 | The inspection list the RCO actually names, the one that has to happen before any work starts at all, and what to do — and record — when nobody is required to inspect you.                                                                              |

## The five documents

|             | Document                | What it does for you                                                                                                                                                               |
|-------------|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>OH.4</b> | Where to File Directory | How to establish whether a certified residential building department covers your parcel, the offices that exist even when none does, and a page to record every one you confirmed. |
| <b>OH.5</b> | Forms & Documents Index | Each document you will meet: what it is, when, and from where — plus the work Ohio exempts from approval outright, listed as the code lists it.                                    |

## HOW TO USE IT

- **Start with OH.1.** Its first section settles whether a certified residential building department has jurisdiction over your parcel. Nothing else in the kit sequences correctly until you know that answer.
- **Then deal with the sewage system.** On a rural Ohio build the household sewage treatment system permit is the longest pole, it comes from your local health district rather than any building department, and it constrains where the house can physically sit.
- **Work OH.2 with a pen.** The approvals that apply everywhere deserve more of your attention than the one that might not apply at all.
- **Keep OH.3 on the job** and record every inspection as it happens — most of all if nobody is required to inspect you. It is the only evidence you will have when you sell, refinance or insure.

### How these facts were checked — and what this is not

Every Ohio claim here was read against its primary source in September 2026 — the Ohio Revised Code and the Ohio Administrative Code at [codes.ohio.gov](https://codes.ohio.gov), and the Board of Building Standards' own filed rule text — and is cited where it appears. Where the answer genuinely depends on your municipality, township or county, the kit says so and gives you a line to write down what you confirmed. Not legal advice.